

Claude Overview and Features

1. The Anthropic - Claude Ecosystem

Anthropic is the parent company of Claude — equivalent to OpenAI → ChatGPT and Google → Gemini. Claude has 4 products:

Product	What It Is & When to Use It
Claude Chat	Conversational AI interface. Good for Q&A, writing, docs (PDF/PPT/Excel/JSON), architecture flow diagrams.
Claude Cowork	Desktop-only agentic tool. Automates tasks on your computer with simple prompts. No coding needed. Best for business/non-tech users.
Claude Code	Agentic coding assistant that runs in the terminal (CLI) or inside VS Code / Cursor. Best AI coding agent in the market right now.
Claude API	For developers — plug Claude's LLM into your own apps, voice agents, or tools using an API key (same pattern as OpenAI API).

- **Key insight** — Claude Cowork was built by Anthropic using Claude Code in just 10 days — proof of Claude Code's raw power.
- Just like ChatGPT changed AI adoption in 2022, mastering Claude's full ecosystem gives you a 2x–3x productivity boost now.
- Most people only use AI for chatting — the real competitive advantage is agentic/automated workflows.

2. Claude Cowork — Agentic Desktop Automation

2.1 What Is It?

- A sandboxed VM (Virtual Machine) running inside the Claude Desktop app — only available on Desktop, NOT on the web version.
- Think of it as a dedicated Linux server mounted to your laptop — it can read/write your local files (with your permission).
- Runs tasks autonomously using simple English prompts — no coding knowledge required.
- All task output goes via Claude's API (Opus 4.6 / Sonnet 4.6) and returns as structured results.

2.2 Architecture (What Lives Inside the Sandbox)

- **File Access / Mount** — Read & write your local laptop folders — only the specific folders you grant access to.
- **Skills** — Markdown (.md) instruction files that tell the agent exactly how to perform a specific task.
- **Connectors** — MCP (Model Context Protocol) links to 3rd-party tools: Gmail, Slack, GitHub, Notion, MS 365, Atlassian, etc.

- **Plugins** — pre-built bundles of Skills + Connectors = a complete ready-to-use AI employee or team.
- **Sub-Agents** — When Claude breaks a task into sub-tasks, each sub-task is executed in parallel by sub-agents.
- **Claude in Chrome** — Browser automation agent triggered from within the sandbox — runs as a Chrome extension.

2.3 How a Task Executes — Step by Step

- Step 1 — Input: You give a task via prompt.
- Step 2 — Planning: Claude creates an internal plan — which tools to call, what info to gather.
- Step 3 — Decompose: Large task is broken into sub-tasks
- Step 4 — Execute: Sub-agents run all sub-tasks in parallel using assigned skills.
- Step 5 — Validate: Results are coordinated and verified before delivery.
- Step 6 — Output: Final validated result is returned to you.

Every completed task also creates a CLAUDE.md file capturing the full task details — useful for resuming work later.

2.4 Installation & Pricing

- **Install** — Go to claude.ai → Download → Claude Desktop (Windows 64-bit or Mac). Double-click, log in with Gmail.
- **Always update** — Anthropic pushes near-daily updates. Always upgrade to the latest version before starting work.
- **Free plan** — Claude Chat only. Cowork is NOT available on the web, only on Desktop.
- **Pro plan (~\$20/month)** Full access to Cowork, Code, Projects, Memory. Strongly recommended.
- **Max plan (~\$100/month)** Higher usage limits. Use when Pro feels too restrictive.
- **Team / Enterprise** — Needed for native Microsoft 365 connector inside Cowork.

2.5 Left Panel — Cowork Interface Options

- **New Task** — Start a new agentic task.
- **Search** — Search past tasks.
- **Schedule** — Set recurring tasks (e.g., daily at 9 AM).
- **Dispatch** — Control Cowork remotely from your mobile phone.
- **Ideas** — Pre-built task templates to inspire workflows.
- **Customize** — Access Skills, Connectors, and Plugins settings.
- **Projects** — Create project folders to organize tasks with specific file access.
- **Recent Tasks** — All past tasks listed here — called 'Tasks', not 'Chats'.

2.6 Skills — Detailed Guide

Skills are plain-English Markdown files that give the agent precise instructions for a specific type of task.

- An agent without a skill: can do anything but outputs generic results.

- An agent with a skill: follows a focused instruction set and produces much more accurate, formatted output.
- Skills are just .md files — no coding needed, just plain English instructions.

Default Skills Pre-installed in Cowork:

- **Document Skill** — Prepare Word docs, Excel, PDF, PPT, CSV, JSON files.
- **Skill Creator** — Generates a new custom skill file for any task you describe.
- **Canva Design** — Design tasks using Canva integration.
- **Brand Guidelines** — Maintains brand consistency across all outputs.
- **MCP Builder** — Creates and configures MCP server connections.

How to Add a Custom Skill from GitHub:

- Go to Customize → Skills → Upload Skill (+).
- Search 'Claude Skill Kit' on GitHub.
- Browse the skill library (Marketing, Pricing Strategy, Content Creator, HR, etc.).
- Copy the GitHub directory URL of the desired skill ZIP file.
- Paste in the terminal download command ("download-directory.github.io") → skill ZIP downloads.
- Drag & drop the .zip into the Upload Skill panel.
- The skill appears under Personal Skills — inspect it to see its instructions.
- Reference the skill in your task using the @ symbol.

2.7 Connectors (MCP) - Linking to External Tools

MCP (Model Context Protocol) is the open standard that connects Claude to any external service. Think of it as the 'USB port' for AI tools.

Connector	What Claude Can Do
Gmail	Read emails, draft & send replies, summarize threads.
Slack	Post messages, read channels, send notifications.
Google Calendar	Read/write calendar events, schedule tasks.
GitHub	Read repos, create/comment on issues.
Notion	Read and write pages and databases.
Microsoft 365	Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Teams — Team/Enterprise plan only for native connector.
Atlassian	Jira and Confluence read/write — issues, pages.
Base44	Vibe coding tool — connect for full app development via Cowork.

How to Add a Connector:

- Go to Customize → Connectors → find the service → click Connect.
- Authorize via OAuth — grant only the minimum permissions you need.

- Gmail example: grant 'View messages' and 'Manage drafts/sent' only — not full account access.
- Once connected, Claude automatically uses that tool in relevant tasks.

⚠ Security Rule: Never grant Cowork access to your full laptop. Grant access only to specific project folders. Never put banking details, passwords, or sensitive documents in accessible folders.

2.8 Plugins — Pre-Built AI Employees

A Plugin = Skills + Connectors bundled together as a complete AI employee or team for a specific function.

- One plugin can contain 9+ skills AND multiple connectors.
- Install a plugin and you instantly have a fully-configured specialist agent.

Example Plugins:

- **HR Plugin** — Skills: Comp Analysis, Draft Offer Letter, Interview Prep, Onboarding Plan. Connectors: Slack, Gmail, Calendar, MS 365, Atlassian.
- **Engineering Plugin** — Code Review, Architecture Diagrams, Deploy Checklist, Documentation, Incident Response.
- **Marketing Plugin** — Content Strategy, Brand Kit, Social Media Scheduling, Pricing Strategy.
- **PDF Viewer Plugin** — Read and analyze PDF documents inside Cowork tasks.

2.9 Task Scheduling

- Any Cowork task can be scheduled to run automatically.
- Go to Schedule → Add → provide a name, description, and prompt.
- Set frequency: Daily, Weekly, or Manual + specific time (e.g., 9 AM).
- **Demo** — Scheduled 'Daily AI News' at 9 AM with prompt: 'Get latest AI trends as bullet points.'

2.10 Dispatch Mode — Mobile Control

- Dispatch lets you control Cowork from your mobile phone remotely.
- Setup: Dispatch → Enable 'Keep Awake' + 'Computer Use' + 'Code Permission' → finish setup from mobile.
- Your computer must be awake and online for this to work.
- Once set up, send tasks to your computer from your phone via the Claude mobile app.
- **Demo** — Opened Chrome and fetched news headlines — all triggered from mobile, executed on desktop.

2.11 Claude in Chrome — Browser Agent

Claude in Chrome is a browser automation agent. It navigates websites, fills forms, extracts data, and searches multiple tabs — all via prompts.

5 Key Capabilities:

- **Page Reading** — Scrapes full page content including sites that block standard API access.
- **Form Filling** — Fills online forms automatically — e.g., submit interest forms at 10 car showrooms in one command.

- **Data Extraction** — Extracts web datasets for research, lead generation, or custom data sets.
- **Multi-Tab Search** — Opens and searches multiple tabs in parallel.
- **Scroll + Paginate + Click + Navigate** — Scrolls pages, moves across paginated results, clicks buttons — behaves like a human user.

Limitations:

- **CAPTCHA** — Cannot bypass CAPTCHAs — requires manual authentication.
- **Payment walls** — Cannot complete payment flows — requires manual action.
- **Security** — Never give banking credentials or sensitive passwords to the browser agent.

Setup Steps:

- Settings → Connectors → Claude in Chrome → Connect (installs Chrome extension automatically).
- Settings → General → Enable 'Browser Use' AND 'Computer Use'.
- Claude can now control your browser and desktop as a full agent.

2.12 Microsoft 365 Integration

- **Native Connector (Team/Enterprise)** - Settings → Connectors → Microsoft 365 → Connect. Available only on Team or Enterprise plan.
- **Workaround for Pro/Free** — Open Excel/PowerPoint → Home → Add-ins → Search 'Claude' → Add → Authorize. Full Cowork features available inside the Office app.

3. The CRISP Prompt Framework

CRISP is the recommended structure for writing effective prompts for Claude agents — ensures maximum accuracy, minimizes hallucinations.

Letter	Meaning & Example
C — Context	Your background / business situation (not passwords — real relevant context). Example: 'I run a SaaS for creative freelancers.'
R — Role	Assign Claude a role. Example: 'Act as a senior HR manager' or 'You are a business analyst.'
I — Instruction	The specific task. Example: 'Find last month's sales data and prepare a summary report.'
S — Specific / Constraint	Set boundaries. Example: 'Only look at Sheet 1, columns A–F, last 3 days only.'
P — Output Format	Specify exact format. Example: '10-slide PPT in white & black theme' or 'Bullet points under 20 words each, saved as summary.md.'

4. Claude Chat — Key Features & Settings

4.1 How to Access Claude

Platform	How to Open
Web	Go to claude.ai in any browser. Free plan available.
Desktop App	Download Claude Desktop (Mac or Windows). Left=Chat, Centre=Cowork, Right=Code.
Mobile	Search 'Claude by Anthropic' on Play Store or App Store. Install and sign in.

4.2 Pricing Plans

Plan	What's Included
Free	Claude Chat only — no Cowork on web, no Code tab. Good starting point.
Pro (~\$20/month)	Full access: Chat, Cowork, Code, Projects, Memory, Artifacts. Strongly recommended.
Max (~\$100/month)	Higher usage limits + extended context window. For heavy professional use.
Team / Enterprise	Microsoft 365 native connector, advanced security, organisational billing.

4.3 Core Chat Capabilities

- **File Upload** — Upload PDF, Word, Excel, PPT, JSON, CSV, images — Claude reads and analyses all of them.
- **Image Analysis** — Drop any screenshot or photo — Claude describes, interprets, and answers questions about it.
- **Screenshot** — Take a screenshot directly from inside Claude and ask questions about the screen content.
- **Web Search** — Enabled by default — Claude searches the internet for current information automatically.
- **Output Styles** — Choose Normal, Learning, or Concise Explanation — pre-defined response formats.
- **Model Selection** — Opus (most powerful), Sonnet (balanced, recommended), Haiku (fast & cheap).
- **Extended Thinking** — For complex tasks — Claude reasons deeply step-by-step before generating the answer.
- **Notifications** — Enable in Settings so you're notified when a long task finish — keep working while it runs.

4.4 Memory — The Most Important Feature

Memory lets Claude remember you across all conversations — so you never have to re-introduce yourself or re-upload context each session.

How to Enable:

- Settings → Capabilities → 'Generate memory from chat history' → Enable.
- Claude then automatically builds a profile of you from all your past chats.

How to Import Memory from Other AI Tools:

- Settings → Capabilities → 'Import memory to Claude' → copy the provided prompt.
- Paste the prompt into ChatGPT or Gemini → copy the output.
- Paste back into Claude → 'Add to Memory' → your full context from other tools loads within minutes.

Reviewing & Resetting Memory:

- Regularly check: Settings → Capabilities → Memory → Review — ensure Claude has accurate info about you.
- Wrong info? Capabilities → Reset Memory → Claude starts fresh.
- Project memory is private ('only you') files added to projects do not go to the internet.

4.5 Projects

Projects are dedicated workspaces for repeating use cases. Configure once — reuse every time. No context setup needed each conversation.

- Create a project: name + instructions + knowledge base (text or uploaded files).
- Every chat inside that project automatically inherits those settings.
- You can create multiple projects: business, personal, client-specific.
- Files added to a project stay private - not sent to the internet.

Pro Tips for Projects:

- **Add real business files** — Upload your product info, pricing, company background — Claude uses them automatically.
- **Set language & format** — Specify preferred output language and format inside the project instructions.
- **Keep contexts separate** — Separate project for business vs personal work avoids context bleed.

4.6 Artifacts

Artifacts let you build fully interactive apps, games, calculators, quizzes, and templates — directly inside Claude Chat. No code editor required.

- Artifact types: App, Website, Document, Template, Game, Productivity Tool, Quiz, Survey.
- Once created, you can publish and share via a public URL.
- Built with auto-generated HTML/CSS/JS — runs in browser immediately.

Business uses for Artifacts: EMI calculators, expense trackers, team quizzes, time management tools, business portfolio pages, client intake forms — all shareable web apps in minutes.

4.7 Settings to Configure

- **Personal Preferences** — Settings → 'What best describes your work?' → Enter your niche/role → Claude tailors all responses to your context.

- **Notifications** — Enable response-completion notifications — stay productive while Claude works on long tasks.
- **Theme** — White/Dark mode — personal preference.
- **Font** — Use Chand (or system default) for clean readability.
- **Voice** — Choose your preferred voice for voice mode responses.

5. Claude Code — Agentic Coding Assistant

5.1 What Is Claude Code?

- Best agentic coding assistant in the market as of 2026.
- Runs as a CLI (Command-Line Interface) in your terminal or inside VS Code / Cursor / JetBrains.
- Unlike Claude Chat (which gives code for you to copy-paste), Claude Code creates, edits, validates, and tests files autonomously.
- Task-oriented — give a goal, Claude handles the full loop: plan → write → validate → fix → deliver.

5.2 Claude Chat vs Claude Code — Key Difference

Mode	How It Works
Claude Chat (Assisted Coding)	You ask → Claude gives code → You copy-paste into editor → You validate → You loop back with errors. YOU do all the manual steps.
Claude Code (Agentic Coding)	You give a goal → Claude plans, creates files, writes code, validates, fixes errors — all in one place. Claude does the full loop.

- **Vibe Coding vs Agentic Coding** — Vibe coding = prompt-only, output-oriented, you may not understand the code. Agentic coding = full understanding + control + Claude assists execution.

5.3 Where to Access

- **Claude Desktop** — Right tab in the Desktop app — all features available in one UI.
- **Terminal / CLI** — Install and run in any terminal. Standalone and powerful.
- **VS Code** — Install as an extension. Claude Code sits inside your editor.
- **Cursor / JetBrains** — Full support as a plugin.

5.4 Desktop Interface — Feature Guide

- **Model Selection** — Sonnet 4.6 (default, recommended), Sonnet 4.7 (1M context), Haiku 4.5 (cheapest), Opus (most intelligent).
- **Project Folder** — Select the working folder — all files Claude creates/edits go here.
- **Plan Mode** — Claude shows you a plan of what it will do and waits for approval before editing any files. Start here.
- **Edit Mode** — Claude directly creates and edits files after plan approval.
- **Auto Mode** — Plans and edits automatically — Claude asks only for critical actions.
- **Bypass Permission** — DANGEROUS — skips all permission prompts. Avoid this.

- **/slash Commands** — Built-in: /architecture, /review, /security-review, /batch, /brand-review, and more.
- **Connectors** — Add 3rd-party tools: 159+ total.
- **Plugins** — All Engineering / HR / Marketing plugins are available here too.
- **Verbose Mode** — Full detailed logs of every step — useful for debugging.
- **Diff View** — Shows exactly what code changed — like a git diff.
- **Terminal** — Run shell commands directly from the Claude Code UI.
- **Files Panel** — Browse all project files and search within them.
- **Tasks Panel** — Monitor running or queued sub-agent tasks.

5.5 Installing in Terminal

Platform	Install Command
Mac / Linux	brew install claude-code
Windows CMD (not PowerShell)	npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code

First Steps After Install:

- Type 'claude' in terminal → authorize with your Anthropic account (browser OAuth).
- Select dark/light mode → skip or fill preferences.
- Type '/model' → select model. Stay on Sonnet 4.6 by default.
- Type 'Shift+Tab' → toggle between Plan Mode, Edit Mode, General Mode. Start in Plan Mode.
- Settings → Claude Code → Enable 'Auto Permission Mode' (not Bypass).
- Type 'plugins' to browse and add engineering/marketing/HR plugins.
- Keep-up to date: 'brew upgrade claude-code' or equivalent.

5.6 Model Selection Guide

Model	When to Use
Sonnet 4.6 (Default)	Best cost/quality balance. Use for 90% of tasks. Achieves complex work in 2–3 iterations.
Sonnet 4.7	1 million token context window. Use for large codebases or very long documents.
Opus 4.x	Most intelligent. Use only when Sonnet fails after 2–3 tries. More expensive — use sparingly.
Haiku 4.5	Cheapest and least capable. Use only when cost is the hard constraint and task is very simple.

Rule of thumb: Stay on Sonnet 4.6. Switch to Opus only when a task is genuinely too complex for Sonnet. Never default to Opus — you'll burn through your Pro usage limit very quickly.

5.7 Key Settings

- **Plan Mode vs Edit Mode** — Always start in Plan Mode. Review Claude's plan, confirm it's correct, then allow edits.
- **Auto Permission Mode** — Claude handles routine permissions itself; only asks for critical/sensitive actions.
- **User-Level Settings** — Stored in your account — apply across all projects (dark mode, font, etc.).
- **Project-Level Settings (CLAUDE.md)** — Stored per project — specific instructions for that codebase only.

5.8 Initialization File — Critical Concept

Every agentic coding tool uses an init file to maintain project context across sessions. Without it, Claude 'forgets' what the project is about when you return after a break.

Tool	Init File
Claude Code	CLAUDE.md — auto-created in your project folder.

- Claude Code auto-generates CLAUDE.md — but add your own project goals, tech stack, and design decisions to it.
- When you return to a project, Claude reads CLAUDE.md first and resumes with full context.

6. Security Best Practices

- Never grant Cowork access to your full laptop — always specify only a specific project folder.
- Do not store banking statements, passwords, or private keys in any folder accessible to Cowork.
- If you want, use 'Auto Permission Mode' in Claude Code — NOT 'Bypass Permission Mode'.
- When connecting Gmail/other tools, grant only the minimum required permissions.
- In Claude Code: always start in Plan Mode — review the plan before allowing file edits.
- Run /security-review first whenever you load an existing codebase or folder.
- Regularly review Memory settings — ensure Claude has accurate, appropriate info about you.
- Project files are private — files added to Claude Projects are NOT sent to the internet.

7. Quick Reference — Which Tool for Which Task

I want to...	Use This
Organize my downloaded files automatically	Claude Cowork — New Task with folder access
Summarize a PDF and save it	Claude Cowork — Document Skill
Get daily AI news every morning	Claude Cowork — Scheduled Task at 9 AM
Draft a job offer letter	Claude Cowork — HR Plugin

I want to...	Use This
Research competitors & build pricing strategy	Claude Cowork — Pricing Strategy Skill (from GitHub)
Book a flight or fill in car showroom enquiry forms	Claude Cowork — Chrome Browser Agent
Scrape comments from a YouTube video	Claude Cowork — Chrome Browser Agent + File Access
Build an Excel report with web-sourced data	Claude Cowork + Excel Add-in + Browser Agent
Create a pitch deck in PowerPoint	Claude Cowork — PowerPoint Add-in
Build a landing page or web app	Claude Code — Agentic mode, HTML/CSS
Refactor or debug existing code	Claude Code — Terminal or VS Code
Create an interactive quiz or budget tracker	Claude Chat — Artifacts
Write emails, documents, research summaries	Claude Chat
Build a custom AI tool or voice agent for my company	Claude API
Control Cowork from my mobile phone	Claude Cowork — Dispatch Mode

8. Quick Checklist

- ☐ Download and install Claude Desktop (Mac or Windows).
- ☐ Sign in and choose plan.
- ☐ Enable Memory: Settings → Capabilities → Generate memory from chat history.
- ☐ Import memory from ChatGPT / Gemini if you have history there.
- ☐ Run first Cowork task: folder organization demo with Desktop folder access.
- ☐ Connect Gmail via MCP: Customize → Connectors → Gmail → Connect.
- ☐ Install a Plugin: Customize → Browse Plugins → install HR or Marketing plugin.
- ☐ Set up a Scheduled Task: e.g., Daily AI News at 9 AM.
- ☐ Install Claude in Chrome: Settings → Connectors → Claude in Chrome → Connect.
- ☐ Enable Browser Use + Computer Use in Settings → General.
- ☐ Set up Dispatch Mode on your mobile phone.
- ☐ Install Claude Add-in in Excel and PowerPoint (Home → Add-ins → Claude).
- ☐ Create a Project in Claude Chat for one of your key recurring use cases.
- ☐ Build an Artifact: budget tracker, quiz, or calculator app.
- ☐ Install Claude Code in terminal or VS Code.
- ☐ Practice writing CRISP-framework prompts for your real daily tasks.